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DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Spotted lanternflies have been found in almost 150 communities in Massachusetts, about triple last year's infestation.

A gooey invasion spreads

Lanternfly nymphs threaten trees, bedevil farmers and homeowners

By Bryan Hecht
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

The spotted lanternfly, an invasive insect that can imperil certain kinds of trees and create headaches as its sticky excrement mists down onto patios and cars, has now been found in almost 150 communities in Massachusetts, about triple this time last year, officials say.

Just weeks ago, New Hampshire officials recorded what could be their first ever wild lanternfly population, spurring concerns that the pests are moving north.

Native to Asia, spotted lanternfly larvae pierce plants and the bark of trees, feeding on their sap, leaving behind a sticky residue, and inviting mold growth. They can be especially active around grapevines and maple, apple, and black walnut trees. While the adult bugs can fly, they mostly hop rapidly from place to place.

During a serious infestation, hundreds

PESTS, Page A10



Nymphs of the lanternfly have accumulated in Worcester. The city's Green Hill Park also has signs warning of another invasive insect: the Asian longhorned beetle.

The T, as in tardy, trying, tiresome, terrible . . .

Can Boston pretend to be world-class when it can't even get folks to their destinations?

By Kara Miller
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Several years ago, I was invited to a fancy party on Beacon Hill. One of the invitees asked the hostess what T stop she lived near, and she replied she had no idea.

The answer floored me, because she probably lived 150 feet from the Park Street Station. I bet you

COMMENTARY

could have seen it from her amazing balcony.

But it served as a good reminder that lots of people with power — either financial or political — know next to nothing about the T. Because they don't ride it.

Earlier this year, when I was

writing about concerns that the tech scene in Massachusetts is slowing, one of the power players I talked to noted — in passing — that, though the state faces problems with high costs and talent retention, it's good, at least, that the T has been fixed.

I wanted to stop the conversation and take an hourlong detour into why the T is still incredibly unreliable and too often disappointing, but I swallowed it and stayed focused.

Yes, some improvements have

been made. After 2024 — dubbed “the year of the shutdown” — speeds on the Orange Line and Red Line improved considerably, though, as Transit Matters noted, the Red Line was still plagued by “frequent delays caused by disabled trains and signal problems.”

The improvements are not nearly good enough. And the quality of the T has real bearing on Massachusetts' competitiveness and its ability to retain workers trying to build careers here.

MBTA, Page A6

Schools brace for cellphone fallout

Lawmakers' lack of action, transparency on proposed ban intensifies concerns

By Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

Tens of thousands of Massachusetts children will pack their backpacks, board buses, and return to classrooms this week for the coming school year, joining thousands more who've already had their first day.

All the while, a major change that would shake up school districts sits untouched by the state Legislature.

Language creating a statewide cellphone ban in schools is among a dozen proposals in legislative purgatory on Beacon Hill. That's because lawmakers last year approved an internal rules change that gives them until early January to strike deals on policies locked in closed-door negotiations.

Talk to proponents, and each of the bills demands urgent action in some form or another. But it was the proposed cellphone ban that faced one of the more finite timelines, with schools reopening to students and widespread agreement among lawmakers that the state needed to do something to get cellphones out of their hands.

“It's a huge lift, no matter what you do,” Newton Superintendent Anna Nolin said of implementing a classroom cellphone ban, which her district did

CELLPHONES, Page A6

After years, CVS returns to Roxbury

Pharmacy-only store doesn't include retail

By Alexa Gagosz
GLOBE STAFF

For years, many Roxbury residents who needed a prescription filled had to travel outside the neighborhood. Now, CVS is coming back.

But the storefront that recently opened in Nubian Square won't look very familiar. There are not aisles of makeup, birthday cards, sodas, or snacks. Instead, this stripped-down version is almost entirely centered on pharmacy services: Fill your script, get a flu shot, speak to a pharmacist, or pick up some Tylenol. Shampoo and deodorant are there — but everything is behind the cashier's glass barrier.

This format is part of a broader effort by CVS to provide pharmacies where communities lack access to them and to rethink its traditional stores. It comes while drugstores everywhere face pressure.

Insurance reimbursements, labor, and real estate costs have squeezed margins as drugstores have lost market share on everyday retail to competitors, including Amazon. Meanwhile, executives have said shoplifting has become an increasing concern.

CVS, Page A7

In the news

Israel struck southern Lebanon with an intensifying bombardment that fueled fears the war in the Middle East will reignite. **A3.**

The promising developments around a personalized vaccine for melanoma have experts hoping for a broader horizon for mRNA technology. **D1.**

The average price of regular gas nationwide soars past the record high for Labor Day weekend. **A2.**

The Red Sox won their fifth consecutive game, topping the Angels, 5-2, behind Adley Rutschman. **C1.**

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A loss of coverage amid a bitter breakup

MGB Health Plan cuts Dana-Farber from its Medicare Advantage network

By Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

Eldon Clingan has had the same cancer specialist at Dana-Farber Cancer Institute for more than two decades. He trusts her, he said, and credits her with saving his life.

Starting Oct. 1, though, the 88-year-old retired accountant will either have to find a new oncologist or change insurance plans because his Medicare Advantage plan is dropping Dana-Farber from its network.

The Medicare plan, run by the insurance arm of Mass General Brigham, has about 20,500 members, though only a fraction are receiving cancer care at Dana-Farber at any one time.

MGB Health Plan said the change is driven by financial considerations, including limited federal reimbursements.

But the split comes amid a very public breakup of the longtime partnership between the two institutions, in which Dana-Farber provided inpatient cancer treatment to Mass General Brigham's vast network of patients. US News and World Report ranked Dana-Farber, in partnership with MGB's Brigham and Women's Hospital, as the top cancer hospital in Boston and the third-best cancer hospital in the country.

HEALTH PLAN, Page A7



MELECK ELDAHSHOURY FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Eldon and Carol Clingan worry over insurance changes.



Going, glowing, gone

Tuesday: Sunny late. High 76-81, low 61-66.

Wednesday: More clouds. High 74-79, low 68-73.

Sunrise: 6:17. Sunset: 7:06.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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